

LOCAL NEWS DECEMBER 26, 2014

Suggestions for your winter reading list



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The new year is just about to begin - school is out and many people are enjoying the new e-readers they got for Christmas. If you're enjoying some time off, now is a great time to read, so this week we thought we'd offer a list of staff recommendations for good books to read.

My own recommendation is "The Death of King Arthur," translated by Simon Armitage. In 2009 I recommended Armitage's new translation of "Sir Gawain and the Green Knight," so I thought this time I'd recommend this as a follow up. Armitage does an excellent job of capturing the flavor of the original Middle English of both of these poems and making them accessible for modern readers who aren't interested in pronouncing the "k" in knight and who don't want the hassle of learning letters we haven't used since the 15th century.

Our newest staff member, Eija, recommends Linda Barry's "One Hundred Demons," which she describes as an "autobifictionalography" in comic strip form. This book contains about 20 stories about family and life told in Barry's comic strip form as seen regularly on Salon.com. And our second newest staff member, Jackie, recommends "The Secret History" by Donna Tartt. Jackie describes this as a beautifully crafted story about the loss of innocence, murder and the dangers of pack mentality - an intense, character-driven novel with a smart, engrossing plot line.

Mike recommends "The Greenglass House" by Kate Milford. It's a book about a really cool smuggler's hotel told from the point of view of a boy named Milo, who lives in the hotel where wonderful weird things happen. The book makes you think of the days when you didn't think of instantaneous communication with other people.

Kaylene recommends three books. First, "Behind the Beautiful Forevers: Life, Death, and Hope in a Mumbai Undercity" by Katherine Boo. Forget the dystopian fiction; you can't imagine anything more dysfunctional than the struggle against corruption and disadvantage faced by the poorest Indians. The author spent several years learning about the lives of slum-dwellers, and her portrayal of their lives reads like a novel and provides profound insights.

Secondly, Kaylene recommends "Going Postal" and "Making Money" by Terry Pratchett. If you haven't read Pratchett yet, start with this pair of fantasy novels. They explore the philosophical underpinnings of public institutions such as mail and money, while depicting characters who rise above their own expectations

through a series of rollicking and hilarious adventures.

Kathleen recommends "The Book of Strange New Things" by Michael Faber. In this genre-defying novel, an ex-addict Christian minister journeys to a distant planet named Oasis to preach to its alien inhabitants. Faber eerily evokes the strangeness of alien life forms while still imbuing them with a human-like capacity for love and wonder.

And finally, I'll make a second recommendation myself for local author Brandon Schrand's "Works Cited: An Alphabetical Odyssey of Mayhem and Misbehavior." Considering the emphasis the state of Idaho is placing on getting its high school students to move on to college, I would particularly recommend this book to young adults who are considering going to college. This book tells the story of the pitfalls that will be encountered by any underprepared Idaho high school student attempting to leave the comfortable familiarity of small town Idaho as they move into the world of higher education. Brandon's book is almost two years old now, but I've found myself recommending it to a couple of people just within the last few weeks who hadn't had the chance to hear about it yet, so it's worth mentioning this book by a Moscow author again.

All of us at all seven branches of the Latah County Library District hope that everyone had a happy December and we look forward to serving the residents of Latah County in 2015.

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